

THEME-6

BHAKTI SUFI TRADITIONS

1. Explain with examples what historians mean by the integration of cults. (NCERT)

- Historians who have tried to understand these developments suggest that there were at least two processes at work.
- One was a process of disseminating (spreading) Brahmanical ideas.
- This is exemplified by the composition, compilation and preservation of Puranic texts in simple Sanskrit verse, explicitly meant to be accessible to women and Shudras, who were generally excluded from Vedic learning.
- There was a second process at work – that of the Brahmanas accepting and reworking the beliefs and practices of these and other social categories.
- One of the most striking examples of this process is evident at Puri, Orissa, where the principal deity was identified, by the twelfth century, as Jagannatha (literally, the lord of the world), a form of Vishnu.

2. In which two categories, historians of religion often classified Bhakti traditions?

- historians of religion often classify bhakti traditions into two broad categories: saguna (with attributes) and nirguna (without attributes).
- Saguna Bhakti includes traditions which focus on the worship of specific deities like Shiva, Vishnu. Example- Meerabai
- Nirguna Bhakti stresses on worship of an abstract form of god. For example- Kabir and Guru Nanak.

3. Name the major anthology compiled by the alvars which is also described as the Tamil Veda. How did various chieftoms in Tamil region help them in early first millennium century?

Or

Which Tamil text is known as Tamil Veda?

- One of the major anthologies of compositions by the Alvars, the **Nalayira Divyaprabandham**, was frequently described as the Tamil Veda, thus claiming that the text was as significant as the four Vedas in Sanskrit that were cherished by the Brahmanas.
- The powerful Chola rulers supported Brahmanical and bhakti traditions, making land grants and constructing temples for Vishnu and Shiva.
- Some of the most magnificent Shiva temples, including those at Chidambaram, Thanjavur and Gangaikondacholapuram, were constructed under the patronage of Chola rulers.
- Some of the most spectacular representations of Shiva in bronze sculpture were produced.

4. Mention the two earliest Bhakti movements of Tamil Nadu, giving the main difference between them.

- Some of the earliest bhakti movements were led by the Alvars (literally, those who are in devotion to Vishnu) and
- Nayanars (literally, leaders who were devotees of Shiva).
- They travelled from place to place singing hymns in Tamil in praise of their gods.

5. Who were Virashaivas or Ligayats?

Or

Who were Basavana?

Or

Who led a new movement in Karnataka? What were his followers known as? What were its main principles?

- Brahmana named Basavanna (1106-68) who was initially a Jaina and a minister in the court of a Chalukya king. His followers were known as **Virashaivas** (heroes of Shiva) or **Lingayats** (wearers of the linga).

- They worship Shiva in his manifestation as a linga,
- Men usually wear a small linga in a silver case on a loop strung over the left shoulder.
- Lingayats believe that on death the devotee will be united with Shiva and will not return to this world.
- They do not practise funerary rites such as cremation, prescribed in the Dharmashastras. Instead, they ceremonially bury their dead.
- The Lingayats challenged the idea of caste and the “pollution” attributed to certain groups by Brahmanas.
- They also questioned the theory of rebirth.
- The Lingayats also encouraged certain practices disapproved in the Dharmashastras, such as post-puberty marriage and the remarriage of widows.
- Our understanding of the Virashaiva tradition is derived from vachanas (literally, sayings) composed in Kannada by women and men who joined the movement.

6. Who was Andal and Karaikkal Ammaiyar? What were their contribution.

Or

Write the examples of women devotees of Alvars and Nayanars.

Andal

- Andal was an alvar women whose composition were widely sung.
- Andal saw herself as the beloved of Vishnu; her verses express her love for the deity.

Karaikkal Ammaiyar

- A nayanar women was a devotee of Shiva.
- she adopted the path of extreme asceticism to attain her goal.

7. What were the five major principles of Islam?

- There is one God, Allah, and Prophet Muhammad is his messenger.
- Offering prayers five times a day (namaz)
- Giving alms (zakat);
- fasting during the month of Ramzan
- and performing the pilgrimage to Mecca (hajj).

8. What do you mean by Zimmi?

Or

Give the meaning of Zimma, who were zimmi?

The word ‘ zimmi’ was derived from an Arabic word Zimma which means protection. In other words, the zimmi were the protected people. They were non- muslims including Hindus, Jains, Jews and Christians. They lived under muslim rulership and paid a tax called jizya/jaziya so, they were entitled for protection by the muslims.

9. Name any five Chishti saints on whose tombs people had expressed their devotion. Which out of these is most respected?

Or

Who is known as Gharib Nawaz?

- Shaikh Muinuddin Sijzi Ajmer (Rajasthan)
- Khwaja Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki Delhi
- Shaikh Fariduddin Ganj-i Shakar Ajodhan (Pakistan)
- Shaikh Nizamuddin Auliya Delhi
- Shaikh Nasiruddin Chiragh-i Dehli Delhi

➤ Khwaja Muinuddin, popularly known as “Gharib Nawaz” (comforter of the poor).

10. Explain the meaning of Silsila in Sufism.

Or

What is meant by the term Silsila in context of Sufism? Name the most famous Sufi Silsila.

The word silsila literally means a chain, signifying a continuous link between master and disciple, stretching as an unbroken spiritual genealogy to the Prophet Muhammad. It was through this channel that spiritual power and blessings were transmitted to devotees.

➤ The most famous Sufi Silsila was the Chishti Silsila.

11. Explain the term Ziyarat. Give its purpose.

Ziyarat means pilgrimage to the tomb of Sufi saints. In other words, it means to seek the sufi's spiritual grace (barakat). When the shaikh died, his tomb-shrine (dargah) became the centre of devotion for his followers. This encouraged the practice of pilgrimage or ziyarat to his grave, particularly on his death anniversary or urs (or marriage, signifying the union of his soul with God).

12. To what extent do you think the architecture of mosques in the sub-continent reflects a combination of universal ideas and local traditions?

- Some architectural features of mosques are universal – such as their orientation towards Mecca, evident in the placement of the mihrab (prayer niche) and the minbar (pulpit).
- There are several features that show variations – such as roofs and building materials.
- For Example- A mosque in Kerala has shikhara-like roof.
- Atiya mosque, Mymensingh district, Bangladesh, built with brick.
- The Shah Hamadan mosque in Srinagar, it is one of the best examples of Kashmiri wooden architecture. It is beautifully carved eaves. It is decorated with papier mache.

13. Describe the main features of life in Shaikh Nizamuddin's Khanqah?

- The khanqah was the centre of social life. Shaikh Nizamuddin's hospice built on the banks of the river Yamuna in Ghiyaspur.
- It comprised several small rooms and a big hall where the inmates and visitors lived and prayed.
- The inmates included family members of the Shaikh, his attendants and disciples.
- The Shaikh lived in a small room on the roof of the hall where he met visitors in the morning and evening.
- A veranda surrounded the courtyard, and a boundary wall ran around the complex.
- There was an open kitchen (langar), run on futeh (unasked-for charity). From morning till late night people from all walks of life – soldiers, slaves, singers, merchants, poets, travellers, rich and poor, Hindu jogis (yogi) and qalandars – came seeking discipleship, amulets for healing, and the intercession of the Shaikh in various matters.
- Practices that were adopted, including bowing before the Shaikh, offering water to visitors, shaving the heads of initiates, and yogic exercises.
- Shaikh Nizamuddin appointed several spiritual successors and deputed them to set up hospices in various parts of the subcontinent.

14. Explain the connection between the state and the sufi saints.

Or

What was the cause of conflict between the sultan and the Sufis?

Or

Analyse the relations which exists between the Chishti sufi saint and the state.

- A major feature of the Chishti tradition was austerity, including maintaining a distance from worldly power.
- The sufis accepted unsolicited grants and donations from the political elites.
- The Sultans in turn set up charitable trusts (auqaf) as endowments for hospices and granted tax-free land (inam).
- The Chishtis accepted donations in cash and kind.

- Rather than accumulate donations, they preferred to use these fully on immediate requirements such as food, clothes, living quarters and ritual necessities.
- Kings did not simply need to demonstrate their association with sufis; they also required legitimation from them.
- It was believed that the auliya could intercede with God to improve the material and spiritual conditions of ordinary human beings.
- kings often wanted their tombs to be near sufi shrines and hospices.
- There were instances of conflict between the Sultans and the sufis. To assert their authority, both expected that certain rituals be performed such as prostration and kissing of the feet.
- Occasionally the sufi shaikh was addressed with high-sounding titles. For example, the disciples of Nizamuddin Auliya addressed him as sultan-ul-mashaikh (literally, Sultan amongst shaikhs).

15. Analyse with illustrations, why Bhakti and sufi thinkers adopted a variety of languages in which to express their opinions?

- The Chishti silsila conversed in Hindavi, the language of the people.
- Other sufis such as Baba Farid composed verses in the local language, which were incorporated in the Guru Granth Sahib.
- Yet others composed long poems or masnavis to express ideas of divine love using human love as an allegory.
- For example, the prem-akhyan (love story) Padmavat composed by Malik Muhammad Jayasi revolved around the romance of Padmini and Ratansen, the king of Chittor. Their trials were symbolic of the soul's journey to the divine.
- A different genre of sufi poetry was composed in and around the town of Bijapur, Karnataka.
- These were short poems in Dakhani (a variant of Urdu) attributed to Chishti sufis who lived in this region during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries.
- These poems were probably sung by women while performing household chores like grinding grain and spinning.
- Other compositions were in the form of lirinama or lullabies and shadinama or wedding songs.

16. Who was Mira Bai? Discuss any of her two works.

- Mira Bai was the best-known poetess of Bhakti traditions.
- She composed many Bhajans in praise of Lord Krishna whom she considered as her lover.
- Her songs are very popular in Gujarat and Rajasthan.
- She was against caste system and rejected the norms of caste society.

17. Describe the major teachings of either Kabir or Baba Guru Nanak, and the ways in which these have been transmitted.

Or

‘Kabir was and is to the present a source of inspiration for those who questioned entrenched social institutions and ideas in their search of divine.’ Explain.

KABIR AND HIS TEACHINGS

- Kabir had an important place among all the poet saints. He believed in the Nirguna Bhakti.
- The range of traditions Kabir drew on to describe the Ultimate Reality include Islam: as Allah, Khuda, Hazrat and Pir.
- Verses ascribed to Kabir have been compiled in the Kabir Bijak, Kabir Granthavali and Adi Grantha Sahib.
- He also used terms drawn from Vedantic traditions, alakh (the unseen), nirakar formless), Brahman, Atman, etc.

- (v) The terms with mystical connotations such as shabda (sound) or shunya (emptiness) were drawn from yogic traditions.
- He emphasized the Sufi concept of zikr and ishq (love) and expressed the Hindu practices of nam-simaran (remembrance of God's name).
- He questioned entrenched religious and social institutions, ideas and practices in their search for the Divine.
- He probably crystallized through dialogue and debate with the traditions of Sufis and Yogis. (viii) He believed in divinity rather than any religion.
- He stated that salvation can be attained through Bhakti.
- He opposed the religious rituals of both Hindu and Muslim.

Expression of views

Kabir expressed his views in the language that was spoken and understood by the common people. After his death, the followers spread his views through various means of communication.

GURU NANAK AND HIS TEACHINGS

Baba Guru Nanak (1469-1539) was born in a Hindu merchant family in a village called Nanakana Sahib near river Ravi in predominantly Muslim Punjab. He trained to be an accountant and studied Persian. He was married at a young age but he spent most of his time among Sufis and Bhaktas. He also travelled widely.

- He advocated Nirguna Bhakti.
- He rejected sacrifices, ritual baths, image worship, austerities
- He rejected the scriptures of both Hindus and Muslims.
- For Baba Guru Nanak, the Absolute or "rab" had no gender or form.
- He proposed a simple way to connect to the Divine by remembering and repeating the Divine Name.

Expression of views

Guru Nanak expressed his ideas through hymns called 'Shabad'. He expressed all his views in Punjabi, the language of the region.

in Punjabi, the language of the region. Baba Guru Nanak would sing these compositions in various ragas while his attendant Mardana played the rabab.

18. What were the similarities and differences between the be-shari'a and ba-shari'a sufi traditions?

BE-SHARIA	BA-SHARIA
• They scorned the Khanqah and took to mendicancy and observed celibacy.	• They organized communities around khanqah controlled by Shaikh, Pir or Murshid.
• They ignored rituals and observed extreme forms of asceticism.	• They observed special rituals of initiation. The initiates took an oath of allegiance, wore a patched garment and shaved their hair.
• They were known by different names as Qalandars, Madaris, Malangs, Haidaris, etc.	• The Chishti silsila is the most influential tradition.
• They deliberately defiance of the shari'a they were often referred to as be-shari'a.	• They complied with the shari'a.

SIMILARITIES

- Both laid emphasis on seeking salvation through intense devotion and love for god.
- Both Sufis turned to asceticism and mysticism and were against the growing materialism of caliphate as a religion and political institution.

- Both sought an interpretation of the Quran based on their personal experience.